

Gamification in Education

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1 Introduction

Once, we learned for knowledge.

Then came the points.

Then the badges.

Then the leaderboards.

And suddenly, education was no longer about learning.

It was about XP.

Gamification has become increasingly common in education, with points, badges, levels and rewards being used to motivate students and increase engagement. For Ester, however, gamification is not something she is particularly fond of. Having worked in a school and as a private tutor, Ester has seen how deeply gamification can influence the learning experience. Her father is also a teacher and frequently talks about the use of different methods to engage students. Even in her own professional learning, she has encountered gamification while preparing for the Salesforce Administrator exam, where challenges, badges and progress systems are heavily integrated. Gamification is therefore no longer limited to games. It has become part of education, professional development and everyday learning. This raises an important question: does gamification actually improve learning, or does it simply make education more engaging?

The existing literature does not give a single clear answer. Some studies report measurable benefits: gamified mathematics activities have outperformed traditional lecture-based teaching [1], and in one course 67.7% of students found the gamified version more motivating than the standard format [2]. Other studies are more cautious. A statistics course found that gamification improved students' attitude toward the subject without producing a significant gain in actual learning outcomes [3], and a broader review of negative effects identified loss of performance as the most common drawback, with leaderboards singled out as the most frequently cited harmful element [4]. Taken together, reviews of the field suggest that gamification does have positive cognitive, emotional and behavioural effects overall, but that the quality of the design and the specific game elements used matter as much as the presence of gamification itself [5].

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